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# Middle *East*

A closer reading of the region: economic instability in Iran, renewed risks between Israel and Lebanon, and the humanitarian crisis in Yemen.

NEWSLETTER NO. 01

Three dispatches, one editorial perspective

REGIONAL EDITOR

Tvisha Jindal

# Inside this issue

00 **A Letter from the Editor-in-Chief**
Ozan Demiroglu

01 **Iranian Internal Affairs: Economic Burden and Civil Unrest**
Cyrus Rahbari

02 **Israel and Lebanon: A Renewed Risk of Escalation**
Maya Virani

03 **Yemen is Back in Civil War: Here's What We Know**
Amelia Weinhouse

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**MIDDLE EAST DESK**
Editor · Tvisha Jindal
Writers · Cyrus Rahbari, Maya Virani, Amelia Weinhouse

A NOTE FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

# Dear Reader,

THE BEGINNING OF EIRA JOURNAL

We are living in changing times. Never before have students had immediate access to international affairs, yet access to information is not the same as understanding it. Geopolitical realignment, economic uncertainty, conflict, and changing international institutions dominate our news feeds every day. It is difficult to know where to start- to understand how to analyze, read, or write about International Relations.

That is why Eira Journal exists. Students deserve a platform both to engage seriously with International Relations and to understand the theoretical roots of the field. We want to peel back the layers- we're not simply asking "what happened" but also how we measure it, how this shifts incentives, and which theories might help explain them. Emory eagles deserve opportunities to grow their research portfolios with rigor.

With that being said, our editorial philosophy is built on democratizing access to rigorous research. Our editorial philosophy rests on intellectual curiosity, methodological seriousness, and independence of thought- not allegiance to any political camp.

International affairs cannot be understood through a single geopolitical or theoretical lens. Therefore, it is only fitting that we have made introductions to those times more tailored to your specific interests. We have six regional desks: Middle East, Europe, North America, Asia, Africa, and Latin America. We hope that you can begin your reading from the regions that interest you.

Each week, one of our six regional desks will publish a newsletter examining three major developments in its region. In it, you can find a brief analysis of an issue affecting the region mentioned. We will release longer form academic scholarship once a semester.

As we open this new chapter, I would like to thank our team: this is only the beginning of our journey, and we are excited to continue the work ahead. A special thank you to my Co-Editor in Chief, Rebecca Han, for all of the hours of cooperation and hard work. Lucky for you readers, you will be hearing from her, and not me, next week. Another special thank you to Angel Sosa, Mac Fabens, Nayan Mallubhotla, Nana Donkor, and Dr. Courtney Freer, for bringing this idea to life last year. As we hope to show you, the most successful policies come much before us, from selfless people who contributed without expecting any recognition. We will grant that recognition every time we can.

In a world of changing times, it's imperative to question every assumption, unfamiliar idea, and new development. As long as we focus on those internal changes, there will always be more to understand about the external changes.

Sincerely,

**Ozan Demiroglu**

Co-Editor-in-Chief

THE MIDDLE EAST DESK FEATURE 01 / 03

# Iranian Internal Affairs: Economic Burden and Civil Unrest

By **Cyrus Rahbari**

Eira Journal · Newsletter 01

*Iran's economic pressure and public resistance to government-enforced norms.*

The 2026 Iran War and its increasing internal political tensions have exacerbated economic instability, inciting a new upheaval of the government's enforced societal norms. Recent international sanctions and oil trade export reductions have caused the Iranian rial to plummet to an all-time low exchange rate of one U.S. dollar (USD) to 2.5 million Iranian rials (IRR).[1] This economic strain has led to civil unrest among the Iranian population due to their inability to afford necessities amid extreme price increases. Even though there is great social unrest, the war puts the Iranian people at a disadvantage: They are politically active and disapprove of the government, but the threat of U.S. and Israeli invasion or control has subdued what would normally be a revolutionary. Instead, dissatisfaction has turned into a rejection of social Islamic laws.[2] This combination of internal and foreign affairs creates an unprecedented political tension in Iran.

The ongoing political turmoil after the death of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei has left the Iranian people in an economic depression beyond the normal context of international sanctions. The economy is at a record-low trade rate of one U.S. dollar (USD) to 2.5 million Iranian rials (IRR).[3] For context, that places the Iranian rial as the lowest-valued currency in the world, followed by the Lebanese pound, at 89,500 per USD. For even greater representation of the economic strain in daily life, the U.S. annual inflation rate, a common point of social unrest, is about 3.4%.4 In Iran, the current inflation rate is 89.8%, with the annual interest rate sitting at 73.6%.5 This makes Iran's current inflation rate approximately 25 times greater than the U.S. inflation rate, increasing social unrest and the economic burden on the people of Iran. Reuters reported that "Iran's leaders may radiate bullishness in their war with the United States, but life is becoming ever tougher for ordinary citizens unable to afford basic necessities or rent as a US blockade cuts the state's financial lifeline - oil exports."6 Families are cutting back on groceries because prices have risen dramatically. Shoppers who previously bought five or ten of a single item may now buy only two. Ultimately, there is an economically induced state of heightened uncertainty and stress amongst the Iranian people.

The economic crisis has also contributed to broader social unrest, but this unrest has not led to a political uprising.[7] Unlike the 1979 revolution, the early 2026 protests led to more social unrest and increased governmental distrust. Dissatisfaction has increasingly appeared through everyday forms of civil noncompliance and resistance to government-enforced social norms. Despite the government's legal requirement for women to cover their hair in public, increasing numbers of women have appeared in public

without the hijab, turning personal dress into a form of political and social expression.[8] During the Tehran 5K race, countless women were seen openly running in the streets without the mandatory hijab, cutting against the rule of law by the Islamic government.[9] This resistance represents a broader challenge to the government's authority over private and social life, particularly as economic hardship further decreases public confidence in the state's ability to provide stability. Consequently, Iran's current unrest reflects not only frustration with economic conditions but also an increasingly visible tension between the government's expectations for social conformity and the behavior of portions of its population.

Iran's economic instability has created an opportunity for political change. However, this uprising has not led to governmental power shifts or regime change. There is still great potential for political movements to form. The government's active attempts via media and internet blocks have suppressed these movements so far, but as the revolutionary history of Iran shows, political tensions and economic burdens can create the long-term social environment for political change.

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THE MIDDLE EAST DESK FEATURE 02 / 03

# Israel and Lebanon: A Renewed Risk of Escalation

By **Maya Virani** Eira Journal · Newsletter 01

*Fragile diplomatic progress, competing security demands, and the costs of renewed confrontation.*

Three months after Israel and Lebanon signed the Trilateral Framework Agreement, tensions have resurfaced between the countries. The agreement, initially brokered by the U.S. State Department, outlined a framework towards peace between the nations, and both sides had committed to early progress.

However, recent developments show that neither side has fully followed through on the deal. Lebanon has not fully disarmed Hezbollah, a political and militant group founded in 1982, and Israel continues to bomb Southern Lebanon. United Nations peacekeepers have reported daily violations of Lebanese airspace by Israelis.[1]

Currently, Lebanon is working on implementing the Trilateral Framework agreement signed on June 26 between Lebanon, Israel, and the United States, which aims to provide security to the Lebanese-Israeli border. The United States remains an active participant in supporting efforts to broker peace. A recent meeting on Monday, September 28, 2026, in Washington, D.C., occurred between Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam and US Secretary of State Marco Rubio.[2] Rubio reaffirmed support for an independent Lebanon free from the influence of Hezbollah and Iran, and commitments to advancing peace talks between Lebanon and Israel.[3] Salam and Rubio's meeting highlights the US State Department's role in helping resolve the conflict. However, it also shows how dependent the nations remain on US involvement.

Reintroducing peace to the region is vital for long-term stability, economic prosperity, and quality of life. For example, Lebanon's already fragile economy will be subject to more challenges. The World Bank projects that Lebanon's GDP will contract by 6.4% in 2026 due to the renewed conflict, as opposed to its growth of 4.2% in 2025.[4] The conflict also has an impact on social dimensions of life in Lebanon, with long-term migration of people from their homes to non-conflict zones, disruption in school systems, and reduced access to healthcare. Some of the sectors most impacted by the conflict include the tourism industry and private sector, which typically contribute a great deal to the country's revenue.

Both Lebanon and Israel have experienced negative effects due to the conflict. Around 96,000 citizens from northern Israel have been forced to migrate to flee Hezbollah's strikes and rocket attacks since 2023.[5] The death toll in Lebanon has exceeded 4,000 people, including at least 37 Israeli soldiers. 6

Ultimately, the stakes extend beyond Israel and Lebanon. The conflict is part of a broader set of challenges facing the Middle East, including Iranian tensions, American intervention, and civil unrest.[7] For example, the Trilateral Framework included Israeli withdrawal from southern Lebanon; however, there have been no efforts towards de-escalation. Rather, Reuters reported that Israel is holding an occupied zone inside southern Lebanon and expanding it. The expansion of this controlled territory demonstrates Israel's continued involvement with Lebanon and both sides' mutual distrust in the agreement. Israel believes its occupation is justified on the basis of Hezbollah's presence and armament in the region. However, Hezbollah refuses to disarm if Israel does not leave Lebanese territory. This mutual cycle of distrust is driven by one side's actions being justified by the other's, and can contribute to further conflict. The same broader confrontation has involved Gaza, Iraq, Iran, Syria, Yemen, and the Gulf. Further escalation in Lebanon has the potential to interact with similar regional conflicts. Due to the lack of a formal treaty between the two countries, how this conflict is resolved will set an important precedent for future relations between the two countries.

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THE MIDDLE EAST DESK FEATURE 03 / 03

# Yemen is Back in Civil War: Here's What We Know

By **Amelia Weinhouse** Eira Journal · Newsletter 01

*The resumption of fighting and its humanitarian and trade consequences.*

Beginning in 2014, Yemen has been in a brutal civil war between the Houthis and Yemen's internationally recognized government.[1] In 2022, a landmark six-month ceasefire was put in place that tenuously lasted up until this past July, when Houthis struck Saudi Arabia's Abha airport and reignited this civil war. Since then, there have been over 850 casualties and over 120,000 people displaced by the escalation, according to the UN.

The civil war began in 2014 when Houthi rebel forces took over the capital, Sanaa, which had already been destabilized by the Arab Spring uprising starting in 2011.[2] Although the roots go further back, the Houthis became an armed insurgency in 2004 after the Sunni-majority government tried to arrest their leader, Hussein Badreddin al-Houthi. Al-Houthi has been recognized since 2015 as a global terrorist. In 2015, Saudi Arabia led an intervention to restore the ousted government. Because of the Houthis' ideological ties to Iran and Iranian backing, the conflict is widely seen as a front in the Iran–Saudi proxy rivalry.[3]

The Houthis want two key things in Yemen. First, power in Yemen and support for movements against the US, Israel, and Saudi Arabia. Second, religious and political order: the Houthis' Zaydism, a branch of Shia Islam believing that leadership should belong to descendants of the prophet Muhammad.[4] Overall, their main grievances include political exclusion, economic inequality, and foreign interference, especially by Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

The Houthis have recruited child soldiers.[5] In recent weeks, the Houthis have captured significant territory, including Mokha, an important port for global shipping, as well as Taiz, the nation's cultural capital. The Houthis mainly have control of Yemeni territory nearing the Red Sea, but their attempts to capture mountainous territories have thus far failed.

In response, the Saudi military has carried out hundreds of air strikes on Houthi positions on the Red Sea coast, while the Houthis have launched drones and missiles at cities and infrastructure in south-western Saudi Arabia.[6] Notably, the Houthis say the Saudi Air Force has launched airstrikes across areas of western Yemen since the group captured territory on September 10 and 11. The U.N. confirms some civilian casualties from those airstrikes, as well as hundreds of people wounded in the fighting.[7]

The renewed fighting also raises concerns beyond Yemen. The Red Sea is one of the most important arteries in the global shipping system, with one-third of all container traffic flowing through it. Now that the Houthis control most of the coastline around the Red Sea, the war threatens to disrupt global trade. The Houthis have continually conducted attacks on commercial ships passing through the sea. This poses a major global problem, even beyond the humanitarian crisis at hand. Avoiding the Bab el-Mandeb Strait means more shipping time as well as costs.

So what next? On September 29th, the UN Special Envoy for Yemen met with Houthi negotiators to avert further escalation.[8] It remains unclear whether the talks will produce an agreement between the Yemeni government and the Houthis. In addition, Yemen's needs are severe, with 12.2 million children in need of assistance, 19.9 million people without access to medical care, 20.5 million people without clean water, and 71% of people living in poverty. People in Yemen need this war to end and need further humanitarian aid.[9] Currently, the Houthis have blocked all forms of aid into Yemen. Whether these talks hold, and whether Saudi Arabia continues its airstrikes, will determine if a new ceasefire is possible.

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